CHAPTER 5 :

FORGED IN IRON

By the time Iron Man's first appearance hit newsstand counters, spinner racks and drugstore shelves in 1963, the medium of comic-book artwork had evolved far past its primitive origins of the late 1930s. The Marvel Age of Comics, ushered in by Stan Lee, was just beginning to reshape the industry landscape with its imperfect heroes, trendsetting artists and dynamic, pop-art layouts. But one thing that was an indelible part of comics well before Iron Man made the scene – and remains so to this day – is the nature of comic storytelling. The panel-by-panel exposition of character and plot development is an inherent part of what makes comics the artform they are.

And it is this very fact that gives comics and film their close kinship. Comic storytelling is inarguably similar to the storyboarding process in film, the source material for what later winds up on the silver screen. We now track the storyboarding process behind Jon Favreau's vision for *Iron Man*, providing insights into the creative circle of which he stood solidly in the center.

As *Iron Man* was in its earliest stages, the script was being developed concurrently with the look of the film. For many movies, this might be a sign of dire straits, where concept couldn't possibly catch up to execution in a demanding production environment. But it turned out to be fortuitous, as the nimble design team turned out concept after concept that wound up inspiring the writers and producers to go in directions they hadn't previously considered. Conversely, the writers were able to count on their concept artists and storyboarders to accurately – and quickly – turn their ideas into visuals that Favreau could use to work toward his vision.

The result? A critically acclaimed blockbuster of a film. Forging iron, indeed!

